CHAPTER 7

THE LAST DANCE – DAY THREE

12 July 2024, 11:26am

ENGLAND vs WEST INDIES, 1st Test, *Lord's – Day 3*

England 371; West Indies 121 & 136

England won by an innings and 114 runs

On the third morning, there is only a maximum of an hour of cricket likely to be played, for which the result is a total foregone conclusion. We've won the game by a distance. Normally, this would mean empty crowds on the final day, there being no reason to get in. Today, my final day for England, there's not an empty seat anywhere in the ground. People rush in manically from the outside, needing to be there for the opening moments. I walk out for the last time, through that dressing room, down those stairwells, to be met by a guard of honour in front of me. I'm semi-sheepish still to be receiving it and walk through feeling quite shy about the whole thing. It doesn't temper the sense of strange occasion though and where two days earlier I had felt heavier, loaded with expectation and lucklessness, today there is a sense of true alignment. From the very first ball, I am swinging it at will. It is going around corners, almost playfully. Joe Root keeps checking the ball, confused, it being in bad shape. 'It's so weird,' he tells me. 'It looks like a dog chewed this. I've never seen a ball like it swing.' We will decide later in the chicken shop that it is divine intervention, but for now, I don't think and just bowl.

I'm bowling at the Nursery End and the ball is swinging. It's the best feeling in the world. Josh Da Silva waits. I know what ball I'm going to bowl. I've visualised it all the night before. It's the magic ball. The one that